

OREGON CITY COURIER

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Published Thursdays from the Courier Building, Eighth Street, and entered in the Postoffice at Oregon City, Ore., as 2nd class mail matter.

Subscription Price \$1.50.

Telephones: Pacific 51; Home A-51.

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WHAT THE FIGURES SHOW

Discussion of the relative merits of the councilmanic and commission form of government has heretofore been more a matter of argument than of actuality. Claims in favor of both systems have been made and supported by figures obtained in some specific instance, but there has been possible no general comparison. Now, however, the Department of Commerce, of the federal government, has issued a detailed report upon 24 cities for the years 1913 and 1915. Eight of these cities have had councilmanic government for the two years, eight have had commission government, and eight had councilmanic government in 1913 and commission government in 1915. The cities ranged from 30,000 to 300,000 in population, and a very comprehensive idea of the result, of the commission form of government can be gathered from the figures set forth in the report.

The figures show that the business of conducting municipal government in the 24 cities has increased in the two years considered in the report. So, also, have taxes increased in every case. Revenues increased, too; but they did not increase in proportion to expenses. Reduced to a per capita basis these figures tell an interesting story.

Per capita taxes in the councilmanic cities in 1913 amounted to \$14.73; in 1915 they amounted to \$16.36. Per capita taxes in the commission cities in 1913 were \$11.11; and in 1915 they were \$12.31. Per capita taxes in the last group of cities were \$10.08 in 1913 under councilmanic rule; in 1915, under a commission rule they were \$11.24. These figures, and all others that are herewith given, are averages. In other words, taxes increased \$1.63 in the two years in councilmanic cities; \$1.20 in the commission cities; and \$1.16 when the change was made from the first form to the second.

Per capita revenues under councilmanic government averaged \$22.78 in 1913; in 1915 they averaged \$23.68. In the commission cities the per capita revenue in 1913 was \$19.53; in 1915 it was \$20.84. Cities in the group that had councilmanic rule in 1913 had an average per capita revenue of \$15.69; in 1915 under commission rule this per capita revenue was \$17.80. Per capita expenses in the councilmanic group in 1913 were \$23.70; in 1915 they were \$28.33. In the commission form group the per capita expense for 1913 was \$19.92. In the commission form group the per capita expense for 1915 was \$22.20. In the last group the per capita cost of government under councilmanic government was \$16.44 in 1913; and under commission government in 1915 it was \$18.76.

None of the cities lived within their incomes during the period upon which figures were gathered. In the councilmanic cities it cost each citizen 92 cents more than his share of the revenue receipts to meet municipal charges during 1913; and during 1915 it cost each citizen \$4.65. In the group of cities governed under the commission system, the excess cost of operation per capita was 39 cents in 1913 and \$1.37 in 1915. In the third group the excess of expense over revenue, reduced to a per capita basis, was 74 cents under councilmanic rule in 1913, and 96 cents under commission rule in 1915.

Up to this point the figures are favorable to the commission form of government. While expenses increase in all classes faster than did revenues, it appears that a saving was made by the commission form of government when the change was made from the older councilmanic form. However, there are other things in municipal affairs besides revenue, expense and taxes. There is indebtedness and cash in the treasury. The per capita indebtedness of the councilmanic cities was \$38.38 in 1913 and \$46.00 in 1915. The per capita indebtedness of the commission cities was \$54.77 in 1913 and \$56.94 in 1915. The per capita municipal debt in the

last group was \$36.81 in 1913 under councilmanic government, and \$39.16 under commission rule in 1915.

As to cash in the treasury the report shows that in the councilmanic cities in 1913 there was \$5.50 per capita; in 1915 there was \$5.12. In the commission cities the per capita share of cash in the treasury was \$4.36 in 1913 and \$3.34 in 1915. And in the last group there was \$5.47 in the treasury for each inhabitant of the councilmanic ruled cities in 1913; yet when these cities adopted commission government this per capita share dropped to \$4.90.

The councilmanic cities paid \$5.39 per capita on the city debt in 1913; in 1915 they paid \$7.11. The commission cities paid off debt at the per capita rate of \$6.92 in 1913, and at the rate of \$5.36 in 1915. The cities that were councilmanic in 1913 paid a per capita rate of \$5.00 on their debt in 1913; and in 1915, under commission rule, they paid off but \$4.40 per capita. Analysis of these figures is not so favorable to the commission form of government.

In short the federal report bears out what has long been the general impression in regard to the commission form of government among those who were unbiased observers; and that is that the commission form of government costs more per capita to the taxpayer. During the first year or so of commission rule a better apparent showing is made (usually) on the city books; but this showing is made at the expense of the public debt. That is to say, to make the commission form of government seem better, a greater part of the city revenue is used to run the city, and a smaller proportion is utilized to pay off past debts. After the commission form has become established, and the need of "making a record" is no longer so pressing, then more of the city indebtedness is paid off—but the actual cost of government is still more expensive to the taxpayer.

It is interesting to note that according to these government figures the only place where the commission form of government showed a direct saving over the councilmanic form, when they were contrasted, was under the expense account of "sanitation." There the saving was one cent per capita. And this is exactly what happened in Portland—our nearest example of the commission form of government. When Portland's commissioners started in to make a great show of saving they did it in the health bureau work of sanitation—sanitary inspection service. It appears that all commission governments are the same.

WE HAVE WITH US

This is the time of the year when a man in a blue serge suit is to be seen standing before a gathering of several thousand insane people, announcing that the batteries for today will be Jones and Smith for the home team and Brown and Black for the visitors and that it is forbidden to throw pop-bottles at the umpire or for members of either to coach players except from the coaching box. This is the time of the year when the sporting editor comes out a trance in which he has been hovering all winter, sharpens up his pencil, oils his typewriter, gets out last year's score-book, and winds up anew the springs of his vocabulary.

This is the time of the year when the most interesting item in the daily paper—to about two-thirds of its readers—starts off something like this: "Before ten thousand fans and fanettes at Mudbank Park yesterday afternoon Casey opened the season for the pennant winners by stabbing the air three times with his stick as O'Rourke lined the pill down the groove for a trio of counts. He was followed by Smith, who took two and then tore the horsehide off the sphere for a non-stop trip to third. Morgan, the next man up, put the ball through a hole in O'Rourke's left hand, but Dillon at short prevented further joy

by being on the job, and with a quick throw home threatened to cut off Casey's dash. The catcher fumbled the toss, and Casey made a good and hasty retreat to third. McKim singled nicely, Morgan stealing second on the pitch. With the bases full Schmitz waited for a chance to drive in Casey, but O'Rourke showed signs of nervousness, so the big Dutchman stood until he got three balls. A girl in the third-base bleachers smiled at Schmitz at this stage, and the mighty hitter lost his head and swung at the next—a wide one. Determined not to show up a boob he held his bat for the next offering and had a strike called on him. With two to three against him the big Dutchman blew up, and as the last pill came floating through the atmosphere he poked at it savagely just as Casey left for home. Then ensued a pretty dodging match for Casey between third and home, but he was nailed dead on a desperate slide. No runs, two hits."

Lots of folk will read that and know just what it means, and they will even be able to visualize what happened from those cryptic words. That is because we have with us just now the baseball season, in all the frenzy of its opening days.

We also have with us that other form of insanity known in the city as "putting in a garden." Out in the country putting in garden isn't anything remarkable—it is a seasonal thing, done every year, and it is not viewed with extraordinary seriousness. But in the city putting in garden is commenced shortly after New Year, when the seed catalogue arrives, and about this time of the year it is at the height of its excitement. This is the time of the year when hubby has blisters on his hands that interfere with his holding a pen

in his remarks that is not apparent in the later opinion. Yet at that, the good judge may be slyly poking fun at some of us in the course of his philosophy; for we seem to recall that somebody once said that ignorance of the law was no defense. And as probably nine tenths of the criminal actions are brought owing to the ignorance of the ramifications of the law on the part of the criminals, the judge is right after all.

One thing is certain, however, and that is that our courts are needlessly overburdened. It may be because of ignorance, as Judge Campbell says; but we suspect that it is also because of the constant effort on the part of attorneys to "drum up trade." There are attorneys in the county seat who have expressed the hope that "the next district attorney" will start something every day, so that there will be lots of work for attorneys in defending his "victims." And it must also be said that there are attorneys—here and elsewhere—who oftentimes go out of their way to suggest to perfect strangers the advisability of going to law over slight troubles.

Of course attorneys must live; and at the rate the colleges are grinding them out, there are more each day who find it necessary to live, and who earn fees. And while ignorance, of try to find cases from which they may the law or otherwise, will probably continue to provide a large amount of court business; something should be done to lessen the burden now cast upon judges. There are many cases that get into court that should never reach the table before the jurist's bench. And while it may not be possible to throw these cases out of court once they get there; it should be possible to prevent some of them from being filed. Just because a law-

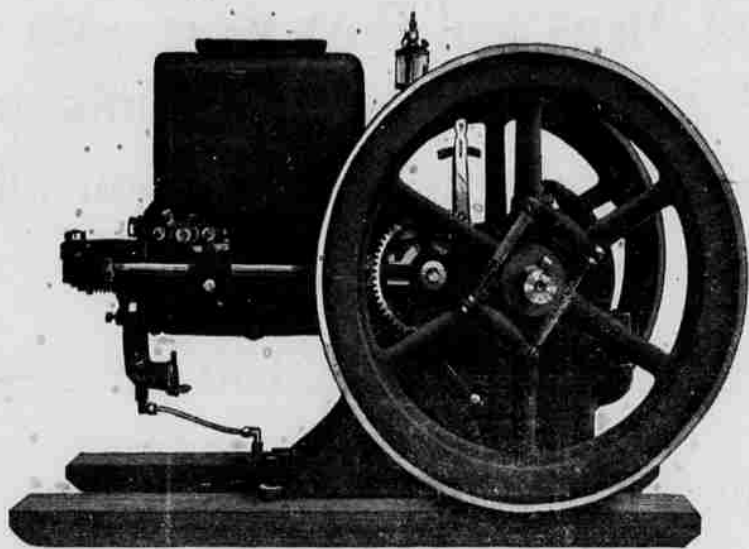
of a special fund. The Eastern Clackamas News doesn't think very much of the occasional fining of resort operators after more or less sensational raids have been made; and in commenting on this matter it says, in part:

"If this keeps on, coupled with the regular raids of the Friars' Club, next year's budget should contain a special appropriation, headed 'For the Arrest, Conviction and Freeing of the Proprietors of the Hotel Belle and Friars' Club—\$10,000,' and we vote a special tax accordingly."

"If the taxpayers would get together and inform the proper officials that unless prison terms were meted out to old offenders, a recall might be started, it might do some good, and a year in jail has a much better effect on a boot-legger, than a \$500 fine, amounting to a part of the profits of his illegal calling."

The same copy of the Eastern Clackamas News tells of the adventures of A. C. Anderson, an enterprising farmer of Upper Garfield, who dropped into Estacada last week to do a little seasonal shopping. Owing to the absence of municipal hitching posts in the business section of Estacada, Mr. Anderson had to tie his team—already loaded with livestock feed—in an outlying section of the city. And then, says the News: "After an absence of a half hour, on returning to the wagon, he discovered that some of the town's horses and cows had made a good, full square meal from his supply of feed, besides having sampled everything from groceries to hardware."

These two matters, taken up in the estimable Estacada paper, remind us of the Biblical injunction about not trying to take beams out of one's neighbor's eye until one removes the



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at the office; it is the time of the year when mother takes Willie's new kid gloves to wear in the garden; it is the season when the soup spoons all disappear—to be found later rusted and dirty under the hyacinths. This is the time of the year when friend wife wishes she had planted the asters in the front yard and the pansies in the shade, instead of the way she did do it. This is also the season of the year when the cook, who forgot to order spinach from the grocer, goes out on the lawn and surreptitiously gathers dandelion greens, and serves them instead—and nobody knows the difference.

In short this is the end of spring and the beginning of summer, and most folks can't help the way they feel and act.

AS TO THE COURTS

Circuit Judge J. U. Campbell last week opined that considerably over nine-tenths of the actions brought in the courts were due primarily to ignorance of legal requirements, helped clutter up the court dockets with suits that were really trivial, said the judge. This pronouncement by the county's leading jurist is just as true—if not more so—than his declaration some months ago to the effect that the one underlying reason for divorce was marriage.

Only when the judge was speaking about divorce there was a vein of wit

yer needs a fee is no reason why the time of the court should be taken up over a trifling matter that could be settled outside of court by common sense on the part of the litigants.

It is hoped that Judge Campbell's remarks will be given heed, and that there will be less "ignorance" in the future, and fewer attorneys willing to capitalize this ignorance. Our courts are our greatest safeguards of true democracy, of fairplay and of justice; and they should not be overburdened with paltry matters. They should not be converted into collection agencies, or into the means of venting petty spite. They should not deteriorate into "happy hunting grounds" for attorneys who lack a certain degree of principle, and who look upon the law merely as a livelihood, and not as an honored profession. And if a few more jurists will express their opinions, as Judge Campbell expressed his opinion, it is likely that in time there will be a reform that will accomplish something for everybody that is deserving—honest judges, good attorneys, and the average common man whose knowledge of the law is extremely brief.

ESTACADA IDEAS

Last week's Eastern Clackamas News thinks it would be a good thing to make an appropriation every year so that the county police officials could make occasional bluffs at law enforcement, and do it at the expense

note from his own opit. It seems to us that after Estacada has abolished stock running at large within its corporate limits, and so emerged from prehistoric darkness, will be ample time for it to tell us how to run the county's police business.

NOT RIGHT YET

Neatly accepting the "call" this paper recently gave it for calling Oregon City a suburb of Portland, the Woodburn Independent last week acknowledged its error thusly:

"Elsewhere is reproduced the Oregon City Courier's opinion of the Independent's opinion of the city by the falls. Possibly we were in error relative to that town being a suburb of Portland and beg pardon for overlooking an important point. One can plainly see that, one being the suburb of the other, Portland is the suburb of Oregon City. Why, certainly."

Of course we ought to be satisfied with that, but we aren't. To say that Portland is a suburb of Oregon City may be considered complimentary by the Woodburn scribe; but in these dignified we don't care to be called the big end of Portland any more than we fancy being called an appendage of the state metropolis. To have Portland labelled an Oregon City suburb makes us in a way responsible for Portland—makes it appear that the funny folk down the river really belong here. And outside of W. S.

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U'Ren and B. N. Hicks we don't know of any Oregon City people who have transferred their allegiance to the burg to the north—that is nobody except Tillie Taylor, that weird literary genius who used to shine on our cheerful contemporary. And probably none of these would admit that they had moved from Oregon City to a suburb of this abode of harmony and bliss.

Oregon City desires to stand distinct and alone—and it usually does. Heaven only knows Potland doesn't claim us; and we don't claim Portland. So we hope the Woodburn Independent will realize this; and let us stand on our own feet—else we may be moved to say something real peevish about Woodburn.

YES, 'TIS INTERESTING

The Benton County Courier last week was quite shocked to learn that imports of booze into Corvallis had greatly increased during the month of March, and after analyzing the imports remarked as follows:

"One of the rather startling disclosures of the figures is that 47 quarts of wine for sacramental purposes were received in Corvallis, which prompts the comment that the sale for this purpose had better also be regulated by some agreement, as far more wine was obtained for this purpose in Corvallis than the rest of the county combined."

The Courier—this one, not the Benton county one—has often wondered why it is that if the sacrament is "merely a beautiful simile, a pious and traditional custom," it should be so very necessary to utilize wine in connection with it in prohibition territory. There are some churches that use grape-juice, ad seem to find that it answers the purpose quite as well. Hence it is interesting—even "startling" as the Benton county paper says—to find that "far more wine was obtained for this purpose in Corvallis than the rest of the county combined. What do you suppose was the reason?"

R. L. Holman and T. P. Randall,

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Along with the flowers and candles that bloom in the spring is a budding newspaper at Milwaukie.

A candidate who has his name written in on the ballot knows that there is a real demand for his services, and that he isn't picked as the lesser of several evils.

The editor of the Columbia Herald, at Houlton, is still throwing out hints that he wants a wife. Somebody ought to take pity on him, if he isn't too particular.

Five hundred dollars isn't much of a fine to impose on the boss of a popular road house—but five hundred dollars and six months in jail is a very different matter.

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Farmers, Attention! We have lately installed a machine for sharpening disc harrows. Please give us a trial—satisfaction guaranteed.—Scripture & May, Fifth St.

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